

A How-to-Guide

CARB LOAD

for your marathon



PLEASE TAKE
ONE

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What you'll find.

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Carb Loading for Marathons

You've put in the training. You're ready for race day. Now it's time to lock and load those carbohydrate stores <aka glycogen> to show off your fitness on race day.

We can store 90 - 120 minutes worth of fuel in our muscles as glycogen. Glycogen is made up of carbohydrates and water. By the end of our training cycle, these glycogen stores are depleted. We must carb load to stock them with fuel for race day.

Carbohydrates are the preferred fuel source for PR race efforts. And, stocking our glycogen stores + taking fuel on race day will ensure that we do not hit the wall and finish with a smile on our face.

So, let's do it...



When: to start carb loading

60 - 72 hours or 2 1/2 - 3
days before your marathon



Carbs = Fast Fuel.
Carbs are the
preferred fuel source
when we are
running fast.

How many: carbs to eat

To fully carb load - we need to eat enough carbs based on our body size.

This is 8 gm/kg carbohydrates per day x 2.5 - 3 days.

Find your weight & daily carb load needs below.

*grams of carbs needed per day
during the 2 1/2 - 3 day carb load

Weight (lbs)	Daily Carb Needs
110 - 120 lbs	400 gm
120 - 130 lbs	450 gm
130 - 145 lbs	500 gm
145 - 160 lbs	550 gm
160 - 170 lbs	600 gm
170 - 180 lbs	650 gm
180 - 190 lbs	700 gm
200+ lbs	750 gm





What: to eat to carb load

Any carbohydrate can be used to carb load. Carbohydrates are found in grains, starchy vegetables, fruit, dairy, and sugar sweetened beverages.

If you have a history of GI issues or a sensitive stomach on race day, carb load with lower fiber foods <ie. the white stuff> to minimize the amount of roughage left in your GI tract that could cause issues on race day.



3-Steps to Start Carb Loading

Step 1: **How much**

Check out page 5 to see how many grams of carbs you need to eat per day to fully load those carb stores, aka glycogen.

Step 2: **What foods**

Think about what foods you would like to eat to carb load. Make these familiar foods you eat regularly and enjoy.

Step 3: **Plan Meals + Snacks**

Break up your total daily carb needs into 50 gm servings. Split those evenly throughout the day between meals and snacks. Don't try to eat too much at one meal.

- 1 large bagel
- 2 scoops Skratch or sports drink
- 4 graham crackers
- 2 slices large bread
- 1 heaping cup cooked pasta
- 1 cup cooked rice
- 2 servings pretzels
- 16 oz juice or lemonade
- 1 1/2 - 2 cups dry cereal
- 2 servings skittles or candy
- 1 large baked potato
- 1 cup dry oats
- 2 bananas
- 1 cup sweetened applesauce
- 2 cups pineapple
- 3 Tbsp honey
- 1/4 cup maple syrup
- 1/2 cup raisins

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Sample Day

500 gm carb



Breakfast

1 cup oats + 1/2
cup raisins, cooked
in almond milk
<100 gm carbs>

Snack

2 servings of
pretzels
<50 gm carbs>



Lunch

Bagel sandwich +
banana + bag of
pretzels
<100 gm carbs>

Snack

4 graham crackers
+ a little PB
<50 gm carbs>

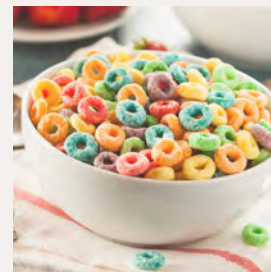


Dinner

2 cups cooked
pasta + sauce +
big hunk of bread
<150 gm carbs>

Snack

2 cups dry cereal
<50 gm carbs>



FAQ.

How will I eat this much food?

Think of carb loading as eating differently - not necessarily more. Increase carbs - decrease fat, protein, and vegetables. Carbs are the star of the show. Use the rest as condiments.

Can I drink my carbs?

Yes! If eating this much food seems daunting, add sports drinks, juice, and lemonade.

Do I need to cut out carbs for a few days before a carb load?

No. Just eat normally the week before your race, then 2 1/2 - 3 days pre-race start carb loading.

Are all carbs equal? Are pasta and donuts equally effective for carb loading?

Yes - all carbs are equal. But, carbs that are high in fat often fill us up and keep us from eating enough total carbs. Try to choose foods that are high in carbs and low in fat. Things like donuts, cookies, chips, and French fries have carbs but are also high in fat. Instead, choose bagels, animal crackers, pretzels, and a baked potato.

I'm afraid to eat too much and weigh myself down.

The science behind carb loading is glycogen = 1 gm carbs + 2 - 3 gm water. If we carb load right, we will hold onto a couple pounds of extra fuel & fluid. This is a GOOD thing. The extra fuel will provide the energy to sustain your fitness - not weigh you down.

Your
questions
answered.

FAQ.

What about shorter distances? When do I need to carb load?

Any race that will take you over 2 hours needs carb loaded. There is some research to support our muscles work better carb loaded, so consider a 1 day carb load before 60 - 90 minute races.

Are some carbs better for carb loading than others?

Nope. The best carbs for you to load with are the carbs your body feels best eating. Don't try anything new. Eat the high carb foods you have eaten all of training, just in larger amounts.

Should I choose 'healthier' carbs like sweet potatoes, beans and quinoa?

Most runners tolerate lower fiber carbohydrates like white pasta, bread, and rice better than the higher fiber whole grains, beans, and lentils. Only carb load with higher fiber foods if you have practiced this and have a stomach of steel.

What about hydration? Do I need to drink more when carb loading?

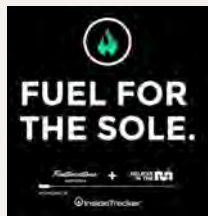
Yes! Glycogen is 1 gm carbs + 2-3 gm water. You need to drink more while carb loading. Keep a water bottle with you at all times - alternate plain water and an electrolyte drink while carb loading.

Your
questions
answered.



Need more help?

Purchase a customized 3-day
Pre-Race Nutrition Plan to nail
your carb load.



Want to hear more?

Tune into Fuel for the Sole
episode 10 where ever you
listen to podcasts.

Found this helpful?

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